

Which of the following sets of symptoms is most consistent with a diagnosis of generalized anxiety disorder? A 39-year-old man who reports:

- ☐ A. difficulty sleeping, fatigue, low appetite, and loss of interest in activities he previously enjoyed. [3%]
- ☐ B. repeated surges of overwhelming anxiety with racing heart, difficulty breathing, sweating, and a fear that he is losing his mind. [21%]
- ☐ C. an exaggerated startle response, nightmares, avoidance of certain situations, and negative thoughts and moods. [12%]
- ✔ ☒ D. difficulty sleeping, muscle tension, fatigue, and worry about his health, finances, and family. [62%]

Correct

62% answered correctly

Explanation:

Anxiety disorders (incomplete list)	
Generalized anxiety disorder (GAD)	• Excessive, uncontrollable worry about a range of topics • Muscle tension; difficulty concentrating or sleeping; feeling restless, fatigued, or irritable
Panic disorder	• Repeated, uncontrollable & unpredictable panic attacks (ie, overwhelming surges of anxiety that peak within minutes)
Specific phobia	• Excessive, irrational fear of a specific situation (eg, flying) or animal/object (eg, spiders)
Social anxiety disorder/ Social phobia	• Intense fear of scrutiny or rejection in social situations (eg, public speaking, asking someone on a date)

Generalized anxiety disorder (GAD) is an **anxiety disorder** characterized by excessive, **uncontrollable worry** about a **range of topics**. Individuals with GAD anticipate disastrous outcomes for daily events and activities, and find it difficult to control their worry. Muscle tension, difficulty concentrating or sleeping, and feeling restless, fatigued, or irritable are all common symptoms of GAD.

Symptoms of widespread worry (ie, anxiety about health, finances, and family), along with multiple physical symptoms (ie, difficulty sleeping, muscle tension, fatigue), are most consistent with a diagnosis of generalized anxiety disorder.

(Choice A) Depression is characterized by feelings of sadness, hopelessness, or emptiness; lack of interest in previously enjoyed activities; changes in appetite; changes in sleep; fatigue; low self-worth or guilt; cognitive difficulties; and/or thoughts about death or suicidal ideation. Difficulty sleeping, fatigue, low appetite, and loss of interest in previously enjoyed activities are most consistent with a diagnosis of depression, not GAD.

(Choice B) Panic disorder is an anxiety disorder characterized by repeated, uncontrollable, and unpredictable panic attacks, which are overwhelming surges of anxiety that peak within minutes. Repeated surges of overwhelming anxiety with racing heart, difficulty breathing, sweating, and a fear of losing one's mind are most consistent with a diagnosis of panic disorder, not GAD.

(Choice C) Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) can arise after exposure to trauma (ie, an event that resulted or almost resulted in death, sexual violence, or serious injury). Hyperarousal (eg, exaggerated startle response), intrusive symptoms (eg, nightmares), avoidance of reminders of the trauma (eg, certain situations), and negative thoughts and moods are most consistent with a diagnosis of PTSD, not GAD.

Educational objective:

Generalized anxiety disorder (GAD) is an anxiety disorder characterized by excessive and uncontrollable worry about a range of events. People with GAD may experience muscle tension; difficulty concentrating or sleeping; and restlessness, fatigue, or irritability.

Time spent:0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:402036
System:
Motivation, Emotion, Attitudes, Personality, and Stress

A 34-year-old patient describes a history of conflict-ridden interpersonal relationships. This pattern has been present since late adolescence, occurs across all settings, and has resulted in a history of sporadic employment and tumultuous romantic relationships. The symptoms are not due to a medical condition or the use of a substance. Which psychological diagnosis is most likely in this patient?

- ☐ A. A mood disorder [13%]
☐ B. An anxiety disorder [2%]
☐ C. A dissociative disorder [11%]
✔ ☒ D. A personality disorder [72%]

Correct

72% answered correctly

Explanation:

Personality disorders		
Marked deviation from expected behaviors causing distress and/or impaired functioning		
Cluster A	Cluster B	Cluster C
Odd/eccentric Paranoid Schizoid Schizotypal	Dramatic/emotional/erratic Antisocial Borderline Histrionic Narcissistic	Anxious/fearful Avoidant Dependent Obsessive-compulsive

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Personality disorders are characterized by **inflexible** and **enduring patterns** of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors that **differ markedly** from social **norms** and cause functional impairment. Individuals with personality disorders have pathological personal traits (eg, rigidity, greediness) and maladaptive patterns of relating to others (eg, hostility, superficiality) that are stable over time and across situations.

For someone with a pattern of conflict-ridden interpersonal relationships in all settings since late adolescence (ie, stable over time), resulting in a history of sporadic employment and tumultuous romantic relationships (ie, significant impairment), the most likely diagnosis is a personality disorder.

(Choice A) Mood disorders (eg, depression) are characterized by persistent disruptions in emotional state. Although individuals with mood disorders may experience social dysfunction (eg, lack of interest in socializing), this is a result of their mood symptomology, not an inflexible and enduring pattern of relating to others (ie, personality disorder).

(Choice B) Anxiety disorders (eg, generalized anxiety disorder) are characterized by excessive worry. Although individuals with anxiety disorders may experience social dysfunction (eg, declining social invitations due to anxiety), this is a result of their excessive worry, not an inflexible and enduring pattern of relating to others (ie, personality disorder).

(Choice C) Dissociative disorders (eg, dissociative identity disorder) are characterized by disruptions in memory and identity. Although individuals with dissociative disorders may experience social dysfunction (eg, through inconsistent interactions with loved ones), this is a result of their disruptions in memory and identity, not an inflexible and enduring pattern of relating to others (ie, personality disorder).

Educational objective:

Personality disorders are characterized by inflexible and enduring patterns of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors differing markedly from social norms. Personality disorders are stable over time and across environments and cause significant distress or impairment of functioning.

Time spent:0 sec**Subject:**

Behavioral Sciences

QID:402037**System:**

Motivation, Emotion, Attitudes, Personality, and Stress

A patient repeatedly presents to his primary care physician with extreme distress about his mild health symptoms, including headaches and fatigue. Although the physician reassures him that these are not symptoms of a severe illness, the patient fears the worst and continues to devote significant time to worrying about his health. Which diagnosis is most likely for this patient?

- ☐ A. A dissociative disorder
- ☐ B. A personality disorder [1%]
- ✓ ☒ C. Somatic symptom disorder [70%]
- ☐ D. Generalized anxiety disorder [27%]

Correct

69% answered correctly

Explanation:

Somatic symptom and related disorders	
Somatic symptom disorder	• Extreme concern regarding one or more physical symptoms (eg, fatigue, pain)
Conversion disorder	• "Neurological symptoms" (eg, paralysis, blindness) that are not explainable by a medical condition
Illness anxiety disorder	• Preoccupation with having or acquiring a serious disease (eg, HIV, cancer)
Factitious disorder	• Symptoms or illness are intentionally fabricated without obvious external gain (eg, disability benefits)

The somatic symptom and related disorders (SSRD) are a group of disorders in which bodily (somatic) symptoms or illnesses are associated with psychological factors. SSRD diagnoses include somatic symptom disorder, conversion disorder, illness anxiety disorder, and factitious disorder.

Somatic symptom disorder (SSD) is characterized by **extreme concern** regarding one or more actual **physical symptoms** (eg, fatigue, pain). Individuals with SSD typically have a high level of anxiety about their health and devote significant time and energy to their symptoms (eg, repeated doctor visits, researching symptoms online).

Therefore, a patient who repeatedly presents with extreme distress about his mild health symptoms and who devotes significant time to worrying about his health despite his primary care physician's reassurances would most likely be diagnosed with somatic symptom disorder.

(Choice A) Dissociative disorders are characterized by disruptions in memory and identity.

A diagnosis of a dissociative disorder would not best account for this patient's symptoms.

(Choice B) Personality disorders, which are characterized by inflexible and enduring patterns of thought and behavior (ie, personality traits) that differ markedly from social norms, are stable over time and across environments while causing significant distress or impairment in functioning. A diagnosis of a personality disorder would not best account for this patient's symptoms.

(Choice D) Generalized anxiety disorder (GAD) is an anxiety disorder characterized by excessive and uncontrollable worry about a *range* of topics (eg, health, finances, career, relationships). Although some individuals with GAD may have health-related concerns, these are not the *primary focus* of their worry as in SSD.

Educational objective:

Somatic symptom disorder (SSD) is characterized by extreme distress and concern regarding one or more actual bodily/physical symptoms (eg, fatigue, pain).

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:

Behavioral Sciences

QID:402038

System:

Motivation, Emotion, Attitudes, Personality, and Stress